



The machines are taking over, one brick at a time

In all those machines taking over the world movies, not a single robot is made out of LEGO. Maybe the biggest threat to mankind are these small versatile bricks, once they get the hang of replicating themselves that is. So far, they have gotten as far as solving a Rubik's cube in about five seconds or so. This is the Cube Stormer, made by a LEGO enthusiast using LEGO Mindstorm pieces. The record time to solve a cube? Just two seconds

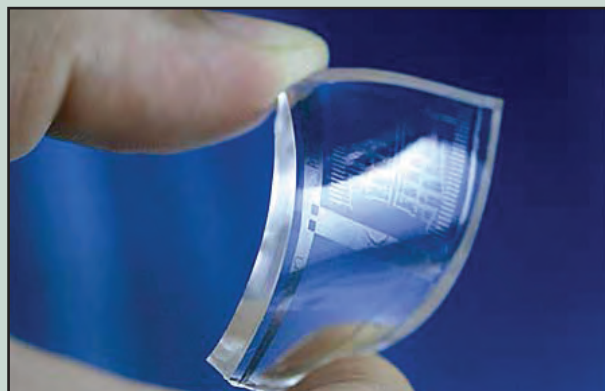
Unwind

Flash Games: Cover Orange 2



Although the title refers to oranges, you have to cover some peaches as well. Basically the game gives you a toolkit of barrels, wheels, crates, and some bombs. Each level is a complex environment that has to be manipulated in such a way that the oranges and peaches are covered... from an onslaught of gear bullets that rains down from a mean cloud. The oranges and peaches thank you if you save them. The game has a great physics engine, and the emotions of the oranges pleading to be saved is very compelling.

Graphene to replace silicon?



Moore's law of exponential growth in computation power has so far held true. However, this might not hold for long as projections into the future predict that silicon based computation will hit a limit in terms of how much performance can be packed into the size. Graphene, however, is seen as the technology that will make silicon obsolete. Graphene is basically a lattice of carbon molecules, with properties that are particularly beneficial to computing. A thin layer of carbon atoms is used to make the small, flexible display shown above. Memory can be stored within the carbon molecules itself, in the "state" of the atoms, which allows for a single unit to have multiple states (instead of the current binary system of the state being either on or off). This means that processing power can be amped up by several magnitudes. Think terrahertz of processing power. The technology is some time away though.

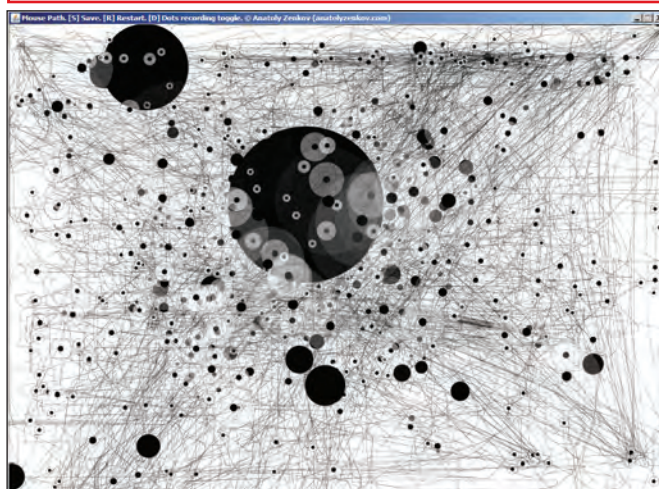
NEWS

The flipside of being connected all the time

The past month, we have seen a number of problems arising from the exploding trend of computers being always online. Forget software and operating systems, even malware is now regularly updated by hackers. A security update by Microsoft, while not taking care of the problem, instead showed a BSOD if the rootkit in question was on the system. When the hackers realised it, they patched the rootkit, making the problem seemingly disappear

In another incident, a school in the US is being sued by outraged parents of students for invasion of privacy. The school issued laptops to all its students, then kept tabs of what is going on in their households by using a spyware that could even send back data from the webcams on the laptops. Why the school thought that it needed to do this is beyond comprehension.

In yet another case, PC gamers with a legit copy of Assassin's Creed II are being unceremoniously thrown out of the game if their internet connection is lost - as an anti piracy measure. We feel that DRM has gone too far in this case.



You can visually map all your mouse activities using mousepath.exe, a small application that runs in the background once downloaded. It tracks the movement of the mouse, assigning lines for the paths, growing black circles for when the mouse is stationary, and white circles for clicks. Post mousepaths at bit.ly/mousepath.

digitDIARY

For this month's Digit TV end credits, we wanted to show an authentic reproduction of how we frag each other at Quake 3. Unfortunately, mid way into the recording of the demos, Cyberjunkie went to the rail pad and picked up a rail. For those who don't know, Cyberjunkie is harder to beat than Xaero in nightmare mode when he has a rail gun. For this reason, rails are banned from the game, whenever the team plays. This sent all the demos out of control. Cyberjunkie's justification was "they will think we are stupid if we don't use rails... what kind of players haven't learnt to use rails?" This meant that we couldn't record the demos in an authentic manner. Ok, we admit it, it actually meant that we couldn't play much at all, except roam around for the few seconds we were allowed to live before being sent back to spawnage hell. If you think you have better rail skills, do get in touch (editor@thinkdigit.com), we are interested in arranging an online showdown.